

The Weekly Digest

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THE WORLD THIS WEEK

Politics

America's Justice Department charged Raúl Castro, former Cuban leader, with the 1996 murder of four Americans of Cuban descent whose aircraft were shot down by Cuban military jets. Secretary of State Marco Rubio addressed Cubans in a video, promising a "better future" for the island. This intensifies America's campaign against the Cuban regime, with military options reportedly being considered.

Venezuela deported Alex Saab, an ally of deposed President Nicolás Maduro, to America where he faces money-laundering charges. Prosecutors may use Mr. Saab to strengthen their case against Mr. Maduro, who

The Weekly Digest

was apprehended by American forces in January.

Bolivia experienced widespread anti-government protests against austerity measures proposed by centrist President Rodrigo Paz. Former leftist president Evo Morales is blamed by officials for inciting unrest, leading America's State Department to compare the protests to an attempted coup d'état.

In Peru's presidential election, leftist candidate Roberto Sánchez advanced to the second round, scheduled for June 7th, where he will face conservative Keiko Fujimori.

Indonesia proposed centralizing commodity exports like palm oil and coal through a new state-owned company and requiring exporters to place earnings in state banks to stabilize the rupiah. The central bank raised interest rates by a larger-than-expected half a percentage point for the first time in two years.

The Weekly Digest

Vladimir Putin visited China, signing trade and cooperation deals with Xi Jinping, including discussions on a new Russian natural gas pipeline for China. China also confirmed an order for 200 Boeing jets after Donald Trump's recent trip, indicating a step forward in trade relations despite previous tensions.

The WHO declared an Ebola outbreak in eastern Democratic Republic of Congo a public-health emergency, with at least 139 deaths and hundreds infected. The response is hindered by ongoing conflict, aid cuts, and the absence of a vaccine for the specific Bundibugyo strain.

America and Nigeria reported killing a top Islamic State commander and 175 militants in Nigerian air strikes, part of collaborative counter-terrorism efforts. However, there is no evidence yet that this has reduced the overall violence in the region.

The Weekly Digest

Fuel price protests in Kenya killed at least four people, leading the government to cut diesel prices and negotiate with transport unions. High oil prices, driven by the war in Iran, are impacting Kenya and other East African nations dependent on Gulf oil supplies.

Donald Trump threatened renewed strikes on Iran but later claimed to have called off an attack at the request of Qatar, Saudi Arabia, and the UAE, citing "serious negotiations." Meanwhile, Iran established the Persian Gulf Strait Authority to manage passage through the Strait of Hormuz.

The United Arab Emirates reported a drone strike from Iraq, where Iranian-backed militias are based, caused a fire at its Barakah nuclear plant. Officials stated they did not know who was responsible for the attack.

Bezalel Smotrich, Israel's far-right finance minister, alleged that the International Criminal Court is seeking a

The Weekly Digest

"secret" arrest warrant for him, calling it a "declaration of war" and blaming the Palestinian authority.

Israel's security minister, Itamar Ben-Gvir, controversially waved an Israeli flag in front of bound, kneeling activists from a Gaza-bound vessel, an incident criticized even by Binyamin Netanyahu. Separately, an Israeli air strike in Gaza killed Izz al-Din al-Haddad, Hamas's military wing head, marking the most senior militant targeted since the October ceasefire.

America's Justice Department created a \$1.8bn fund to compensate those claiming political targeting by federal prosecutors, primarily Donald Trump's allies and supporters, including January 6th rioters. This move is part of a settlement with Mr. Trump related to his leaked tax documents, allowing him to drop his \$10bn damages claim.

A Trump-backed novice, Ed Gallrein, defeated

The Weekly Digest

Republican critic Thomas Massie in an expensive Kentucky congressional primary, while another Trump critic, Bill Cassidy, lost his Senate primary in Louisiana. These victories signal Mr. Trump's continued influence within the Republican Party.

Two teenagers fatally shot three men outside a San Diego mosque before committing suicide. The mother of one gunman had reported him missing and suicidal.

Andy Burnham, Greater Manchester's mayor, emerged as the front-runner to succeed Sir Keir Starmer as Labour leader and potentially Britain's prime minister. However, he is not an MP and faces a challenging by-election in Makerfield, a traditional Labour seat where Reform UK made recent gains.

Peter Magyar, Hungary's new prime minister, made his first foreign trip to Poland, meeting Donald Tusk. Mr. Magyar aims to restore "normality" to Hungarian-Polish

The Weekly Digest

relations, which were strained under his predecessor, Viktor Orban.

A NATO jet shot down a Ukrainian drone over Estonia, with Ukraine attributing the incident to Russian "electronic warfare." Another Ukrainian drone crashed in Lithuania, and Latvia reported similar incursions, following its prime minister's resignation after misdirected drones from Russia damaged an oil facility.

Business

SpaceX officially launched its initial public offering (IPO), aiming to raise around \$75bn and targeting a \$1.75trn valuation on NASDAQ, surpassing Saudi Aramco's record. The prospectus outlined ambitions for off-world data centers, Mars colonization, and asteroid mining, coinciding with the first test flight of its V3 Starship megarocket.

Elon Musk experienced a mixed week, losing a lawsuit

The Weekly Digest

against OpenAI and Sam Altman over the company's shift to a for-profit model. Meanwhile, OpenAI is reportedly preparing for its own IPO in September.

Nvidia reported exceptional quarterly earnings, with overall revenues soaring by 85% year-on-year to \$81.6bn, primarily driven by a 92% increase in data center chip sales to \$75.2bn. The company also announced an additional \$80bn in share buy-backs, reflecting strong performance and investor confidence.

A strike at Samsung was narrowly avoided after a last-minute agreement between management and unions. The unions were seeking a share of the significant profits Samsung has reaped from selling its memory chips to data centers.

Britain's annual inflation rate dropped to 2.8% in April from 3.3% in March, mainly due to a government-imposed reduction in energy price caps,

The Weekly Digest

which saw electricity prices fall by 8.4%. However, a 23% surge in motor fuel costs led to a postponed fuel tax rise, and economists anticipate an overall inflation rate increase in coming months.

America extended a 30-day waiver on sanctions for Russian oil held at sea, aiming to assist poorer nations impacted by Strait of Hormuz supply disruptions. Separately, Britain eased sanctions on Russian oil refined elsewhere, enabling jet fuel imports from India.

Ryanair, Europe's largest airline, stated it was too early to provide accurate profit guidance due to volatile jet fuel prices. Despite being well-stocked and hedging 80% of its fuel costs, the airline warned that spot prices for unhedged fuel had reached \$150 a barrel.

Adani Enterprises agreed to pay \$275m to settle claims of violating American sanctions by purchasing Iranian fuel. Concurrently, the Justice Department dropped its

The Weekly Digest

criminal fraud case against Gautam Adani, and the SEC settled allegations of misleading investors, with Mr. Adani neither admitting nor denying the claims.

Anglo American agreed to sell its Australian coalmining assets for up to \$3.9bn to Dhilmar, a private firm. This divestment follows previous sales of its coal, nickel, and platinum divisions, with the company also negotiating the sale of its De Beers diamond business.

OpenAI's model successfully solved a long-unsolved mathematical problem posed in 1946 by Paul Erdos, concerning the maximum number of points that can be exactly one unit apart on a two-dimensional plane. This "milestone" was achieved by a general AI model without specific mathematical training, overturning previous best efforts.

Swatch launched its Royal Pop pocket watch, a collaboration with Audemars Piguet, combining retail

The Weekly Digest

and luxury markets. The \$400-420 timepieces sparked global queues and even disturbances, with some reselling online for up to \$3,000.

James Murdoch, Rupert Murdoch's son and former News Corporation Europe boss, is acquiring approximately 50% of Vox Media. He expressed interest in "longer-form, thoughtful journalism," a departure from his past involvement in daily newspapers, and Vox Media owns titles like New York magazine.

The weekly cartoon

No significant coverage this issue.

LEADERS

SpaceX is capitalism on rocket fuel

SpaceX, founded by Elon Musk, defies expectations by

The Weekly Digest

achieving seemingly impossible engineering feats like reusable rockets, and now aims to dominate AI with space-based data centers. The company's upcoming \$75bn IPO, the largest in history, could value it at \$2trn, making Musk potentially the first trillionaire. Despite being a loss-making entity with risky financial plans and Musk's full control, the firm represents capitalism's remarkable ability to mobilize resources and drive innovation. While its business plan is ambitious and fraught with financial risks, SpaceX's achievements in space and its competitive drive highlight the transformative power of risk-taking, even with an imperfect company and an imperfect leader.

American growth could be even better

America's economy continues to outperform global peers, with 2% annual GDP growth despite recent "MAGA tax" policies, a mix of high tariffs, zero net migration, and policy uncertainty that shaved 0.75 percentage points off growth in 2025. This performance

The Weekly Digest

is largely attributed to the country's dynamism, resilience, and embrace of disruption, exemplified by its shale revolution and AI data center boom. While Mr. Trump's policies have slowed a historic boom, America's unique advantages like continental scale, single language, and federalism contribute to its sustained economic strength. Other rich countries are urged to emulate America's tolerance for disruption, while future American leaders are encouraged to reverse the "MAGA tax" to unlock even greater potential and raise living standards.

Why NATO needs a Plan B

NATO Secretary-General Mark Rutte's refusal to acknowledge the alliance's potential unraveling, despite Donald Trump's repeated threats to withdraw support for Article 5 and reduce forces in Europe, is criticized as obstinacy. European leaders' attempts to appease Mr. Trump through flattery and increased American arms purchases have not worked, and America's war in Iran

The Weekly Digest

has further strained arms deliveries to Europe and Ukraine. Given the risks of American disengagement and the current delays in promised support, European countries are secretly planning for defense without America, exploring alternatives like Europeanizing NATO structures or strengthening existing multi-national forces such as the British-led Joint Expeditionary Force. Openly planning for a "divorce" is seen as necessary, despite the risks, to ensure a credible European defense.

How to stop the Ebola outbreak

A new Ebola outbreak in eastern Congo, caused by the rare Bundibugyo strain, has been declared a public-health emergency by the WHO and is poised to be the worst in nearly a decade. Unlike the more common Zaire strain, there is no licensed vaccine or rapid test for Bundibugyo, and aid cuts reduced prevention measures prior to its detection. Urgent, coordinated international action is needed to fund vaccine development and deploy

The Weekly Digest

health workers, especially given the region's political instability, where over 100 militias operate and M23 resistance hampers humanitarian access. The crisis underscores the critical importance of robust global disease surveillance, vaccine research, and funding to prevent future pandemics.

Lessons from the Premier League for Britain's next premier

Britain's Premier League, a global football powerhouse generating £10bn annually, offers lessons for the country's next prime minister amid its economic struggles and political turmoil. The league's success stems from its openness to foreign investment, coaches, and players, contrasting with current government policies restricting visas and taxing rich foreigners. Its embrace of ruthless competition and self-regulation, rather than the "nosy managerialism" of a proposed independent regulator, is crucial for attracting investment. Finally, while stability at the top is valued,

The Weekly Digest

the league's experience with underperforming managers suggests that sticking too long with a bad choice, as Sir Keir Starmer is perceived to have done, is a losing strategy, emphasizing the need for decisive leadership to instill belief in a pessimistic country.

LETTERS

Do most baristas in Norway have a master's degree?

Jens Stoltenberg, Norway's Minister of Finance, responded to a Free Exchange column, clarifying that while Norway aims to increase labor supply and productivity, the claim that 70% of baristas have master's degrees is inaccurate. He noted that only 15% of Norwegian workers hold master's degrees and are not concentrated in unskilled jobs, inviting a visit to experience Oslo's high-quality coffee. He also

The Weekly Digest

highlighted Norway's significant military support to Ukraine and lower youth unemployment compared to European averages.

Saket Gokhale, a former MP and national spokesperson for the All India Trinamool Congress, criticized an assessment of Mamata Banerjee's tenure in West Bengal and the BJP's electoral success. He argued that Banerjee's government achieved significant socioeconomic improvements and accused the BJP of democratic backsliding through the deletion of millions of voters, disproportionately targeting marginalized communities.

Kfir Mordechay, an associate professor at Pepperdine University, argued against the pejorative view of "gentrification," advocating for the celebration of affluent families returning to city centers. He suggested that their presence stabilizes the tax base, funding public services for all residents, and offers an opportunity for

The Weekly Digest

institutional renewal, particularly through investment in local public schools.

Dr. Paul Vanderbroeck compared Donald Trump to Marcus Licinius Crassus, a Roman real-estate tycoon who, seeking glory, led a disastrous war against Parthia, leading to his death. Dr. Elizabeth Graham countered the myth of a small Spanish conquest of the Aztecs, highlighting the thousands of indigenous allies who fought alongside Hernán Cortés.

Liam Alastair Crouse disputed the claim that Gaelic receives more government support than Scots due to "Englishness" contamination, attributing it instead to decades of organized activism and institutional development for Gaelic. He also corrected the assertion that Gaelic was banned after the Battle of Culloden and noted the language's severe decline despite support, contrasting it with Scots' larger speaker base. Dr. John Doherty humorously attributed the impulse to distinguish

The Weekly Digest

Scotland from England to "the narcissism of minor differences."

Roland Dehousse, nearing retirement from the European civil service, expressed a "deep connection" to a column on federalists' nostalgia for a mythical Europe, recalling his MEP father's lament: "They promised us a cathedral and built a supermarket instead."

BRIEFING

SpaceX has initiated the biggest ever public offering

SpaceX, Elon Musk's rocket firm, has initiated the largest initial public offering in history, aiming to raise \$75bn and targeting a \$1.75trn valuation on NASDAQ, driven by its ambitious plans to dominate artificial intelligence through space-based data centers. Despite

The Weekly Digest

previous reluctance to go public and ongoing delays with its Starship rocket test flight, the company needs capital to fund its rapidly expanding, yet loss-making, AI venture, xAI, which merged with SpaceX earlier this year. The success of this colossal bet on AI-from-space hinges on Starship becoming fully reusable, Starlink generating more cash, and orbital data centers proving economically superior to terrestrial ones. While investors are expected to be drawn by Musk's "hopes and dreams" premium, the offering carries significant risks due to the unproven nature of the technology, the company's substantial losses, and Musk's unwavering control.

UNITED STATES

Even by Trumpian standards, a \$1.8bn fund for friends is bad

Donald Trump dropped his \$10bn lawsuit against his

The Weekly Digest

own administration, instead securing a \$1.8bn fund to compensate victims of "government lawfare," effectively benefiting political allies like January 6th rioters and anti-abortion activists. This scheme, which bypasses Congress and allows for secret payouts, is criticized as a taxpayer-funded "slush fund" and a melding of law enforcement with the president's personal agenda. The fund's creation, following the illegal leak of Mr. Trump's tax returns, is seen as an escalation of legal weaponization, contradicting his stated aim to end it, and is set to expire before the next election, making his targets ineligible.

Drained by war with Iran, America is stalling deliveries of arms to Europe

America, traditionally the world's leading arms exporter, is significantly delaying deliveries of American-made weapons to European allies due to its own depleted munitions stocks from the war in Iran. This has frustrated European officials, who were previously urged

The Weekly Digest

to boost defense spending and buy American kit to appease Donald Trump and ensure NATO engagement. The scale of the shortage and America's inability to fulfill a massive backlog of orders, particularly for Patriot air-defense systems, is complicating NATO's operational plans and could affect weapon flows to Ukraine. The delays risk undermining trust in America as a reliable arms supplier, prompting European countries to seek alternative, local suppliers, though quickly replacing American capabilities remains a challenge.

America's sermons are becoming op-eds

A study analyzing nearly 90,000 evangelical sermons from 2020-2024 revealed that America's clergy regularly engage in political advocacy despite the Johnson Amendment prohibiting non-profits from endorsing candidates. Using a large language model, researchers found that in presidential election years, about one in seven churches engaged in electioneering, with favorable

The Weekly Digest

references to Republicans (almost 90%) and unfavorable ones to Democrats (over 70%). Donald Trump was the subject of over 50% of political discussions. The study suggests the true rate of political advocacy might be closer to one in two churches, with pastors in Republican counties twice as likely to engage.

Democratic primary voters chose a dicey candidate for Georgia governor

Keisha Lance Bottoms unexpectedly won the Democratic nomination for Georgia governor, avoiding a run-off, thanks to her name recognition and strong support from black women. However, Republicans are eager to campaign against her record as former Atlanta mayor, which was marred by perceived softness on crime, public feuds with Governor Brian Kemp, and her abrupt decision not to seek re-election. Critics argue her past leadership issues will make her a polarizing general election candidate, despite current Democratic voter energy, raising concerns that primary voters may have

The Weekly Digest

risked a crucial Senate seat on an unelectable far-left candidate.

Europe's first known language is alive in America's West

In Boise, Idaho, the Basque language and culture are thriving, unexpectedly preserved by descendants of immigrants who arrived during the California gold rush. A recent legislative bill, House Bill 561, which initially restricted flying non-state flags, drew international concern from the Basque Country's president regarding its impact on the Basque flag during the city's Jaialdi festival. The bill was amended to include a carve-out for the Ikurrina, highlighting the vibrant Basque community, which sustains musical groups, a Basque-language preschool, and social clubs, demonstrating a cultural resurgence after fears of its decline in the late 1970s.

Michigan's Senate primary is a fight over the future of the Democratic Party

The Weekly Digest

Michigan's open Senate seat primary showcases a heated battle among three Democratic factions: Haley Stevens (establishment, pro-Israel), Mallory McMorrow (sensible progressive), and Abdul El-Sayed (far-left populist, anti-Israel). The outcome is crucial for Democrats hoping to gain a Senate majority, especially in a state Donald Trump narrowly won in 2024. While past primary voters preferred moderates, El-Sayed's events draw large, angry crowds disillusioned with the party. The race will also test the influence of AIPAC, which is expected to fund negative ads against the more critical candidates, and the party stalwarts' fear of nominating an unelectable far-left candidate.

Leftist populism's next big test

Graham Platner, an oyster farmer and Marine veteran, is a rising Democratic Senate candidate in Maine, testing the hypotheses that the censorious left can overlook past transgressions and that centrist/right-leaning voters prioritize economic issues over culture wars. His

The Weekly Digest

personal story of overcoming trauma and his focus on economic revolution, such as universal health care and combating billionaires, resonates with struggling Americans. Platner's success has already led to the withdrawal of a popular two-term governor from the primary race, and his populist appeal, especially sharpened by the war in Iran, suggests a potential "earthquake" that could shift the Democratic Party's direction in the Senate.

THE AMERICAS

Donald Trump is pushing towards the end-game in Cuba

Donald Trump's administration is intensifying pressure on Cuba, exemplified by the Justice Department's indictment of Raúl Castro for the 1996 downing of exile aircraft, a move reminiscent of the operation that

The Weekly Digest

deposed Venezuela's Nicolás Maduro. The U.S. views Cuba as a national-security risk and has imposed sanctions on the military-run conglomerate Gaesa, the Castro family's economic arm, and the regime's spy service. While publicly demanding economic reforms and prisoner releases, the administration hints at more drastic changes, possibly including military action, as Cuba faces severe fuel shortages, blackouts, and growing domestic protests amidst an unsustainable economic crisis.

Months after electing a centrist president, Bolivia boils over

Months after centrist Rodrigo Paz's election ended two decades of socialist rule, Bolivia is grappling with violent protests over austerity measures, inherited economic woes, and high inflation. Dynamite-wielding protesters have blockaded La Paz, causing food and fuel shortages, with some groups, including supporters of former leftist president Evo Morales, demanding Paz's

The Weekly Digest

resignation. Despite Paz's efforts at negotiation and limited use of force, the blockades persist, and the economy is projected to contract by 3.3% with inflation exceeding 20% this year. The U.S. State Department has voiced support for Paz's "legitimate constitutional government," warning against attempts to overthrow democratically elected leaders.

Why Brazil's government is obsessed with vaccines

Brazil's left-wing President Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva is heavily investing in the country's medical-industrial complex to achieve "medical sovereignty," particularly in vaccine production, after the covid-19 pandemic exposed the pharmaceutical sector's weaknesses. The Butantan Institute, a state-owned research body, has successfully developed Brazil's first fully home-grown dengue vaccine and is working on others, bolstered by a significant budget increase for the health ministry and an \$11bn industrial program. This new approach involves

The Weekly Digest

government loans, grants, equity stakes, and reforms to speed up clinical trials and attract scientists, aiming to increase the domestic share of medicines and medical equipment. While facing challenges from private sector reluctance, accusations of unfair competition, and the Trump administration's scrutiny of its industrial policies, Brazil seeks broader economic benefits and reduced import costs for its national health service.

ASIA

Why Japan and China will struggle to end their feud

Japan and China's feud, primarily over Taiwan, has intensified, exacerbated by Donald Trump's warming relations with Xi Jinping, which undermines China's incentive for rapprochement with Japan. Japanese Prime Minister Takaichi Sanae's stance on Taiwan as a

The Weekly Digest

"survival-threatening situation" has provoked China, leading to increased maritime tensions and military build-ups, including Japan deploying long-range missiles. People-to-people ties have also soured, with decreased Chinese tourism and anti-Japanese sentiment online. Critical for Japan is China's restriction on rare-earth exports, while the absence of trusted backchannels and a new generation of China-friendly Japanese politicians makes de-escalation difficult, solidifying a sense of entrenched confrontation.

Is Donald Trump selling out Taiwan?

Donald Trump's recent comments following his Beijing visit have deeply unnerved Taiwan, suggesting he views arms sales to the island as a "very good negotiating chip" with China. He implied that America's 44-year commitment not to bargain over Taiwan's defense could be outdated and discussed a \$13bn arms package with Xi Jinping, suggesting its delay depends on China. Trump also portrayed Taiwan's president, Lai Ching-te, as

The Weekly Digest

pushing for independence and risking war, further complicating cross-strait relations. These remarks signal a transactional shift in U.S. policy towards Taiwan and could undermine American commitment to the island's defense, especially after Taiwan's government just passed a supplementary defense budget to fund American arms.

India's loudest political fight obscures a more urgent one

India's political landscape is dominated by a contentious debate between its northern and southern states over parliamentary seat redistribution, which would increase the north's influence due to demographic shifts. While this dispute is driven by the BJP's alleged power grab, it overshadows an equally critical but less noticed problem: the severe underrepresentation of urban voters. Indian cities, home to 40% of the population and generating nearly 60% of GDP, suffer from inadequate public services and dysfunctional local governance. Fair

The Weekly Digest

redistricting and an expansion of the lower house would boost urban parliamentary representation, potentially compelling governments to address the escalating crisis of city life, moving beyond regional grievances to a more cosmopolitan and functional approach.

India's diplomats are hosting the world

India's foreign policy is navigating a complex diplomatic schedule this May, hosting BRICS foreign ministers (including China and Russia) and then the Quad (America, Australia, Japan). This balancing act highlights India's determination to maintain good relations with all major powers, despite inherent contradictions like the Gulf war overshadowing the BRICS meeting, which ended without a joint statement. While the Quad is seen as being on "life-support" due to Donald Trump's disinterest, modest advances in security cooperation are hoped for, though no breakthroughs are expected. Some question whether India is overextending its diplomatic capacity and whether its "vishwaguru"

The Weekly Digest

(world teacher) image aligns with its reluctance to take strong stances on global issues.

Overseas Chinese risk losing their oldest institutions

Overseas Chinese communities in Southeast Asia are facing a decline in their oldest institutions, clan associations, which once served as vital welfare states, employment agencies, and cultural centers for migrants. These groups, often with strict, gender-exclusive membership rules, are struggling to attract younger generations who are apathetic to their historical ties. While new migrants are drawn to more contemporary diaspora groups, the diminishing role of clan associations raises concerns about cultural preservation and integration. Some associations, like Yeoh Kongsì in Penang, are slowly modernizing by admitting women and reevaluating their relevance in a changing world.

The Weekly Digest

CHINA

Vladimir Putin's turn with Xi Jinping

Vladimir Putin's visit to China, immediately following Donald Trump's, showcased Xi Jinping's diplomatic triumph, positioning China as a global geopolitical fulcrum. While both leaders praised Xi and secured agreements, the deals lacked detail, and the visit underscored Russia's growing dependence on China since the Ukraine invasion. Notably, a long-discussed deal for the Power of Siberia 2 gas pipeline did not materialize, revealing China's leverage over Russia in demanding favorable terms. The joint statement condemned American and Israeli actions in Iran, advocated for a multipolar world order, and renewed calls for defense cooperation, reflecting a shared opposition to many aspects of American policy, though specific military aid was not publicly mentioned.

The Weekly Digest

How China quietly helps Russia in Ukraine

China provides crucial "dual-use" components and materials that sustain Russia's war effort in Ukraine, despite claiming neutrality. Chinese microelectronics and semiconductors are vital for Russia's precision-guided missiles and drones, and China supplies most of Russia's commercial FPV drones and associated technologies. Additionally, Russia's weapons factories rely heavily on Chinese computer-numerical-control machine tools, and China is a primary source of nitrocellulose, a key propellant for artillery shells, and its raw materials, often through state-owned firms like Norinco Group using opaque supply chains. This support ensures Chinese firms profit while Russia provides cheap energy, cementing Russia's role as a dependent junior partner.

What China can learn from Japan about escaping deflation

The Weekly Digest

China has entered a deflationary period, reminiscent of Japan's "lost decades" after its property bubble burst, with a decline in domestic spending and producer prices remaining negative for 40 months. While Japan escaped deflation partly due to global shocks like the pandemic and the Ukraine war, leading to cost-push inflation and higher wages, China's current reflation remains narrow, confined to upstream inputs. Despite a global AI spending boom boosting some capital-intensive industries, this hasn't translated into widespread employment or consumer confidence. Chinese policymakers, wary of monetary easing and fiscal stimulus, are not actively pursuing a broader, durable reflation, contrasting with Japan's proactive approach to exit deflation.

MIDDLE EAST & AFRICA

A new Ebola outbreak could be the worst in

The Weekly Digest

a decade

A new Ebola outbreak in eastern Democratic Republic of Congo, caused by the rare Bundibugyo strain, has been declared a "public health emergency of international concern" by the WHO. With nearly 600 suspected cases and 139 deaths, it threatens to be the worst epidemic since 2018, exacerbated by the lack of a licensed vaccine or rapid diagnostic test for this strain, making detection and containment difficult. The situation is further complicated by over a hundred active militias in the region, aid cuts from Western governments, and a weak state, all hindering medical access and trust-building efforts. The outbreak has spread to neighboring Uganda and cases have been detected in Goma, raising fears of wider regional transmission.

How to save the safari

Africa's safari industry faces a critical "trilemma" balancing increasing tourist demand, rapid local

The Weekly Digest

population growth, and pressure on wildlife. Popular destinations like Kenya's Maasai Mara see declining animal populations and habitat degradation due to unchecked lodge expansion and human activities, including farming and fencing. While high-price, low-volume tourism models exist elsewhere, they are hard to implement in competitive markets like the Mara. Some safari firms are adopting new business models, such as paying Maasai communities directly for land leases, to ensure local populations benefit more from conservation than from alternative land uses. However, the overall challenge of funding conservation and resolving human-wildlife conflict remains immense, with proposals for "biodiversity credits" and policy changes being explored.

Is Binyamin Netanyahu facing his last stand?

Israel's government is on the verge of collapse after a preliminary Knesset vote to dissolve itself, triggered by

The Weekly Digest

ultra-Orthodox parties demanding military service exemptions for seminary students. The elections, due by October 27th, will be overshadowed by the legacy of the October 7th attacks and subsequent inconclusive wars in Gaza, Lebanon, and Iran, for which Prime Minister Binyamin Netanyahu faces criticism. While most Israelis support the wars, the campaign is expected to address government subservience to religious interests, the proposed judicial reforms, and rising emigration. Despite polls suggesting Netanyahu's coalition will lose its majority, the opposition lacks a unified leader, and Netanyahu, at 76, may seek to defy expectations again, making the election another referendum on his leadership.

Israel's economy is booming

Despite two and a half years of inconclusive wars, Israel's economy is booming, driven by its resilient tech sector and strong defense-technology exports. GDP experienced a temporary dip due to the March conflict

The Weekly Digest

with Iran, but stock markets, the shekel, inflation, and unemployment all remain favorable. Companies like Nvidia are expanding their presence in Israel, and Western governments are increasing their purchases of Israeli weapons systems. However, economists warn that this high-tech, elite-driven model is demographically unsustainable, as ultra-Orthodox Jews and Arab-Israelis, a growing portion of the population, are underrepresented in the tech sector and receive inadequate education in critical subjects. Critics argue that failing to integrate these communities into the workforce poses an existential threat to Israel's long-term economic resilience and national security.

The mother of the world v the upstart

Egypt's President Sisi's recent understated meeting with UAE ruler Muhammad bin Zayed in a mall symbolized Egypt's declining prestige and its resentment of the UAE's growing regional influence. Egyptians accuse the UAE of encircling their country with separatist

The Weekly Digest

movements and militias, while Emiratis view Egypt as ungrateful for their past financial bailouts. Both nations harbor grievances, with Egypt alarmed by UAE support for Sudan's Rapid Support Forces and its alignment with Ethiopia and Israel, which threaten Egypt's Nile water supply and Gaza border stability. Despite the tensions, neither side will let the quarrel escalate too far, with Egypt seeking to diversify its alliances while facing unsustainable reliance on Emirati aid.

Donald Trump is still looking for a quick fix in Iran

Donald Trump remains reluctant to resume direct military strikes on Iran, repeatedly delaying action based on calls with regional leaders, despite a looming risk of renewed conflict without a deal. He recently claimed to have called off a strike at the behest of Qatar, Saudi Arabia, and the UAE, who assured him a deal was imminent, though Gulf diplomats were surprised by the claim and noted negotiations are stalled. Iran has only

The Weekly Digest

offered a narrow deal to lift blockades on the Strait of Hormuz, leaving trickier issues like its nuclear program for later talks, which is a hard sell for Trump. The administration's repeated search for a "silver bullet" solution, from assassinating leaders to blockades and Chinese intervention, has consistently been disappointed, pushing the situation toward an eventual, perhaps inevitable, resumption of strikes.

EUROPE

Europe's secret Plan B to replace NATO

Donald Trump's repeated cuts to America's military presence and doubt cast on NATO's Article 5 commitment have prompted European nations to secretly plan for defense without U.S. help, or even within a "malfunctioning" NATO. The scrapping of a tank unit deployment to Poland and cancellation of a

The Weekly Digest

cruise-missile unit to Germany, driven by Trump's anger over European support for his Iran war, has upended assumptions of a slow American drawdown. Senior officers now consider command structures like the British-led Joint Expeditionary Force (JEF), a coalition of Nordic and Baltic countries, as a viable alternative to circumvent a potential U.S. veto within NATO, despite Britain's defense underfunding. This "wake-up call" following the Greenland crisis underscores the urgency for Europe to build its own cohesive defense framework.

Who are Europe's newest troublemakers?

Bulgaria and Romania are emerging as Europe's new "awkward squad," potentially replacing Hungary as sources of Eurosceptic populism, fueled by economic malaise and high inflation. In Bulgaria, Russia-friendly populist Rumen Radev became prime minister after campaigning on an anti-graft platform, promising to dismantle "oligarchic governance" and increase Russian fossil fuel imports, while also advocating for a swift

The Weekly Digest

peace in Ukraine. In Romania, the liberal government was ousted by a no-confidence motion backed by the centre-left Social Democratic Party and the rising nationalist Alliance for the Union of Romanians (AUR), which now presents itself as anti-austerity. While Mr. Radev may be less troublesome in practice due to economic incentives, both leaders express views that resonate with "MAGA-world" foreign policy and raise concerns for pro-EU leaders.

Real Madrid's boss calls an election

Florentino Pérez, Real Madrid's president for most of the last 25 years, has unexpectedly called an election for the club's presidency, despite only 16 months into his current four-year term. Under Pérez, Real Madrid achieved significant dominance and revenue growth, but the team has recently been dysfunctional, without a major trophy for two years, and faces fan discontent. The expansion of the Bernabéu stadium has also vastly exceeded its budget. Pérez, a 79-year-old construction

The Weekly Digest

magnate, faces a challenge from Enrique Riquelme, an energy business owner, but the strict rules for challengers and Pérez's enduring influence mean his bid may still fail.

How Europe is fighting for digital sovereignty

Europe is determined to escape its growing digital dependence on American tech giants, driven by concerns over data security, geopolitical weaponization of technology, and the need to foster domestic innovation for economic growth. Initiatives include France switching government computers to Linux, Germany developing a sovereign cloud, and the EU preparing a tech-sovereignty package. Despite "sovereign offerings" from American hyperscalers like Microsoft and Google, critics call these "sovereign-washing" as the firms remain ultimately under U.S. control. While Europe has regulatory tools like the Digital Markets Act to curb anti-competitive behavior, overcoming the integrated

The Weekly Digest

services and scale of American providers, coupled with its own industrial coordination challenges, remains a tall order, necessitating public funds and procurement rules favoring European suppliers.

Bre-entry may be the next drama to grip the European Union

The idea of Britain rejoining the European Union, once a "Remainer fever dream," is gaining traction among Labour politicians, hinting at a potential "Bre-entry" in the 2030s. While some EU leaders would welcome a G7 country with significant global influence back into the bloc, others recall Britain's past half-hearted membership and its opt-outs from key policies like the euro and Schengen. Reaccession would involve navigating a complex process with national vetoes and could face demands for Britain to adopt the euro and Schengen as a test of its commitment. The EU would also seek broad cross-party agreement in Britain to ensure its long-term commitment, suggesting a lengthy and tortuous journey,

The Weekly Digest

but one that could establish the EU as the continent's "manifest destiny."

BRITAIN

In football, Britain has a world-beating industry

Britain's Premier League is a global cultural and economic powerhouse, broadcast to 191 countries and generating £10bn annually, with Arsenal recently clinching the league title. Its success, which contrasts with the dire state of English football in the 1980s, is attributed to three main factors: early export of broadcast rights, attracting a massive international fanbase; substantial imports of foreign owners, coaches, and players; and a competitive structure that redistributes TV revenues more equitably than other European leagues. Despite clubs' precarious finances, often reliant on

The Weekly Digest

foreign investors, and looming concerns about rule-breaking scandals, the league's astonishing sway continues, though a new Independent Football Regulator is set to implement changes that could alter its vibrant landscape.

Why football attendance is booming outside the Premier League

While the Premier League enjoys global glamour, attendance in England's lower professional football divisions is growing fastest, with the Championship being Europe's second-best-attended domestic league. This trend is driven by more affordable ticket prices compared to the Premier League, where Tottenham Hotspur tickets average £76. Beyond economics, lower-league games offer a more authentic, grassroots experience for fans seeking community. The absence of controversial video assistant referees (VAR), which slows down Premier League matches and blunts emotional moments, is also cited as a significant draw

The Weekly Digest

for purist fans.

The legal case hanging over Man City and the Premier League

Manchester City, a highly successful English football club, faces over 100 charges from the Premier League for alleged breaches of financial fair play rules and non-cooperation, spanning 14 seasons during which they won seven league titles. The case, currently being adjudicated by an independent commission behind closed doors, has caused frustration due to the lengthy wait for a verdict and fueled conspiracy theories. If found guilty, City could face severe penalties ranging from fines to points deductions or even expulsion, a decision that would likely trigger appeals and legal challenges, making it the most consequential case in English football history.

Britain's second-biggest city goes from dysfunctional to worse

The Weekly Digest

Birmingham, once hailed as the world's best-governed city, has plunged into dysfunction, mirroring Italy's fragmented politics. Recent local elections left no party with a majority on the city council, a stark contrast to Labour's healthy majority in 2022, reflecting widespread fury at both local and national Labour parties. The city declared a financial crisis in 2023, plagued by equal-pay claims, failed IT systems, and ongoing refuse worker strikes, leading to steep tax increases. This situation, an extreme example of increasing hung councils across England, threatens the urban West Midlands' prosperity and highlights a broader crisis of governance and ethnic segregation in Britain's large, diverse cities.

Labour's battle for ideas is a skirmish over small differences

A "battle of ideas" is ostensibly underway within the Labour Party for leadership, with Andy Burnham advocating "Manchesterism" (localism, business-friendly socialism) and Wes Streeting pushing for EU rejoining.

The Weekly Digest

However, this contest is characterized by more rhetoric than substance, with smaller differences between the left and right camps than apparent. Both sides diagnose a "rentier economy" and propose similar solutions, like tighter regulation of essential industries and taxing wealth more, though specific proposals on tax and borrowing are less radical than they seem. The debate largely avoids crucial questions like long-term public spending cuts and Britain's trading relationships in a protectionist world, as well as the impact of AI, suggesting a "holiday from reality" that prioritizes leadership aspirations over effective governance.

Hate Labour? Vote Labour!

The Makerfield by-election, a Labour "heartland" in a former mining area, is a paradox-laden contest where a Labour activist urged a Reform UK voter to vote Labour to oust current Labour Prime Minister Sir Keir Starmer. This "upside down" political landscape reflects the contortion of terms like "left behind" and the changing

The Weekly Digest

demographics of formerly staunch Labour seats now voting Reform. Andy Burnham, the Labour candidate aiming to become Prime Minister, personifies this paradox, positioning himself as an outsider despite a long political career. The outcome in Makerfield, a constituency often perceived as overlooked but central to recent political narratives, will significantly influence the future leadership of the Labour Party and the government.

INTERNATIONAL

Home-schooling is on the rise around the world

Home-schooling is rapidly growing globally, with numbers more than doubling in America since 2019 and significant increases in other countries, driven by parents' concerns for their children's physical and

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psychological safety, and dissatisfaction with traditional education. While once associated with specific demographic groups, home-schooling parents now mirror the general population and increasingly include families of color and LGBTQ+ individuals. They prioritize curiosity, confidence, and customized learning, believing traditional schooling is rigid and outdated. However, research presents a mixed picture on academic performance and social integration, and concerns about isolation and potential mistreatment have led some countries to implement stricter regulations, though many American states maintain remarkably relaxed oversight, even subsidizing home-schooling.

Israel the lonely

Israel perceives itself as fighting for survival in a dangerous neighborhood, enduring solitude despite global criticism over the Gaza war and attacks on Iran. While many governments condemn its actions, some privately admire its toughness and seek intelligence and

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defense technology, particularly Arab partners like the UAE and strategic allies like India. Relations with America are at a high point under Donald Trump, with unprecedented military cooperation. However, the security establishment fears Trump's misreading of Iran and a potential deal that doesn't end Iran's nuclear program. Domestically, there's concern over Israel's erosion of bipartisan U.S. support and a growing recognition among some Israelis, like former Shin Bet director Ami Ayalon, that neglecting Palestinian statehood aspirations leads to an "ever lonelier place" for Israel.

1843

Dope and glory: inside the Enhanced Games

The Enhanced Games, a new competition openly

The Weekly Digest

embracing performance-enhancing drugs, is set to launch in Las Vegas with \$25m in prizes, attracting athletes like Olympic swimmer Ben Proud. Founded by Aron D'Souza and backed by venture capitalists like Peter Thiel, the games aim to disrupt conventional sport and normalize drug enhancement, also serving as a marketing platform for the company's "performance-enhancing products" for everyday consumers. Despite criticism from anti-doping agencies and ethics concerns, the organizers, including scientific adviser Guido Pieves, frame it as a medically supervised trial to push human limits and offer athletes financial opportunities often lacking in mainstream sports. The company, which recently went public with an "unproven business model," faces financial challenges and the controversy of promoting drug-fueled human enhancement.

The Weekly Digest

BUSINESS

AI super-apps are remaking China's internet

China is rapidly entering an "agentic era" of the internet, where AI super-apps are performing a wide range of tasks for users, such as ordering coffee. This shift, following an era dominated by mobile super-apps, is driven by tech giants like Alibaba, ByteDance, and Tencent, which possess extensive digital services and logistics networks. These companies are fiercely integrating their chatbots with their core platforms (e.g., Qwen with Taobao, Doubao with Douyin, Hy3 with WeChat) to seek new growth avenues amidst anaemic consumer spending. Competition is intense, with some tech firms launching AI-embedded smartphones, and the possibility of regulatory intervention if major players attempt to stifle new entrants.

The Weekly Digest

Google is dethroning OpenAI as the king of consumer AI

Google is positioning itself as the leader in consumer AI, unveiling a new line-up of AI agents powered by its Gemini 3.5 Flash model, to be integrated into the Gemini app (900m monthly users) and Google Search (3bn users). These agents are designed to perform daily tasks and rival OpenAI's offerings, leading to a "Code Red" at OpenAI. While Google's parent company, Alphabet, has seen its market value soar, the success creates problems: its services consume quadrillions of tokens monthly, driving capital expenditure to \$190bn this year. Solutions include efficiency improvements, usage caps for subscribers, and integrating ads into AI responses, as companies are rapidly exceeding their token budgets.

Chanel's creative revival is paying off

Chanel is experiencing a creative revival under new creative director Matthieu Blazy, leading to increased

The Weekly Digest

sales and operating profit last year, and topping fashion rankings for the first time. After an uninspired period under Virginie Viard and a wider industry downturn, Blazy's collections have garnered "Blazymania," refreshing the brand's image while retaining its hallmarks. This success contrasts with struggling competitors like LVMH and Kering, whose fashion sales are down, and even Hermès is showing signs of slowing demand and falling resale prices for its coveted bags. Blazy's adept marketing, including lavish preview events and quick product-to-store timelines, has significantly boosted Chanel's desirability and market presence.

The strange fate of Hard Rock Cafe

The Hard Rock Cafe, a restaurant chain founded in 1971, is increasingly perceived as *passé*, with several locations closing due to losses. Despite this, Hard Rock International, the company behind the brand, is thriving under the ownership of the Seminole Native American tribe, who acquired it in 2007. The Seminoles have

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expanded the brand into a hospitality empire encompassing 15 casinos and 36 hotels, with revenues reaching \$7.9bn in 2025. The ubiquitous restaurants now primarily serve to maintain brand visibility, while the casinos, hotels, and a growing online gambling app, Hard Rock Bet, are the true money-spinners.

How Star Wars went from space opera to soap opera

After a six-year hiatus, the Star Wars film franchise is returning to cinemas with "The Mandalorian and Grogu," testing its big-screen appeal after Disney's shift to extensive TV series. Disney, which acquired Lucasfilm in 2012, prioritized streaming content like "The Mandalorian" to boost Disney+ subscriptions, making seven live-action series since 2019. However, this has diluted the brand and created complex, interwoven plotlines that casual fans struggle to follow, while international audiences are less familiar with the TV characters. The new film's modest budget lowers the bar

The Weekly Digest

for success, but its performance will be a key indicator for future, larger-budget Star Wars movies, and for the broader value of the franchise across Disney's theme parks and merchandise.

A new mega-deal shows how AI has turned utilities into hot property

NextEra Energy, the world's largest listed utility, announced a \$124bn acquisition of Dominion Energy, marking the latest mega-deal in a sector invigorated by AI's surging power demand. NextEra, which has pivoted to a diversified energy approach including natural gas and nuclear power, plans to invest over \$220bn in capital expenditure, leveraging Dominion's regulated business to maintain its credit rating. This merger, however, must overcome regulatory scrutiny in Virginia and the Carolinas, where voters blame the AI boom for rising energy bills, and NextEra faces the challenge of persuading Americans that this "golden age of power demand" will also benefit them.

The Weekly Digest

Can an Italian company disrupt Germany's broken railway industry?

Luca Cordero di Montezemolo aims to disrupt Germany's crisis-ridden railway industry by expanding his Italian high-speed rail operator, Italo, into the market by 2028. Italo plans a ?3.6bn investment for new routes, aiming to replicate its success in Italy, where it spurred a 40% fall in rail prices. However, Italo faces a significant challenge in Deutsche Bahn, Germany's state-owned company plagued by underinvestment and bureaucracy. Italo's entry depends on obtaining multi-year track access from DB InfraGO, a Deutsche Bahn subsidiary, amidst concerns that competition would undermine Deutsche Bahn's integrated business model and exacerbate an already overburdened network.

The benefits?and dangers?of optimism

Optimism offers significant benefits, correlating with better health, resilience, and career advancement,

The Weekly Digest

particularly for entrepreneurs and managers who are more optimistic than employees. Power itself can fuel optimism, and confidence often propels individuals into leadership roles. However, excessive optimism carries dangers, such as increased risk-taking (e.g., smoking, illiquid assets), project failures, and a reluctance to abandon failing initiatives. The appropriate level of optimism depends on context, with a "pre-mortem" process and diverse team composition suggested as countermeasures against bias. While ingrained pessimism can hinder progress, optimism ultimately drives action and success, teaching more than failures do.

FINANCE & ECONOMICS

How much is Donald Trump costing America's economy?

The Weekly Digest

Donald Trump's "MAGA tax" policies, including high tariffs, zero net migration, and policy uncertainty, are estimated to have shaved 0.7-0.8 percentage points off America's GDP growth in 2025. Despite a robust economy buoyed by an AI boom, soaring stock markets, and 2025 tax cuts, actual growth (2.1%) lagged behind what it could have been (2.7%) without these drags. Direct economic impacts include tariffs reducing purchasing power (0.2 percentage points) and negative net migration shrinking labor supply and demand (0.2 percentage points). Furthermore, policy uncertainty has led to a significant contraction in non-AI business investment, reducing GDP growth by 0.4 percentage points, a "capex recession" that is expected to continue and worsen with the Iran war.

The insurers on the hook for war in Iran

The Iran war has severely impacted two niche insurance sectors: political violence and marine war. Political violence insurers face billions in claims from attacks on

The Weekly Digest

energy infrastructure, potentially erasing years of revenue, with premiums for some assets surging 40-fold and coverage narrowing. Even if peace is declared, premiums are expected to remain high due to sustained skepticism and revised risk assessments. Marine war insurers, while not yet facing similar losses, face uncertainty if the Strait of Hormuz remains closed, as "blocking and trapping" clauses could trigger massive payouts for thousands of stranded ships, far exceeding losses from the Ukraine conflict.

The other China shock

China's manufacturing success, unlike Japan's "flying geese" model, continues to dominate low-end industries globally, despite its rising wages and sophistication. This "demographic pterodactyl" effect is partly due to China's vast size and staggered development, allowing poorer regions to compete with lower-income countries while richer cities rival Japan. Chinese firms also provide valuable components for labor-intensive goods

The Weekly Digest

assembled elsewhere, further inflating its export share. Moreover, Chinese policymakers are actively resisting the natural evolution of industries by using automation and high-tech methods to maintain competitiveness in low-end manufacturing, thus leaving less space for poorer countries to fill these niches.

Economics lessons from Home Depot

Home Depot, the world's largest DIY chain, serves as a barometer for the American housing market, with its comparable sales falling or flat for three years, and customer transactions down 9% since 2021. This reflects a gridlocked housing market, where annual transactions have plummeted by 30% in two years, reaching three-decade lows. Homeowners with low pandemic-era mortgage rates are reluctant to sell, and high new mortgage rates deter first-time buyers. This "loss-aversion" behavior has frozen sales volumes without significantly impacting prices. The recent surge in energy prices due to the Iran war further threatens to

The Weekly Digest

push up inflation and mortgage rates, keeping the housing market on ice, prompting Home Depot to increasingly court professional builders over DIY customers.

Where expat escapees from Dubai end up

The war in Iran and missile attacks in the UAE have prompted a significant exodus of well-heeled expatriates from Dubai, who are now seeking new, more peaceful havens. Enquiries for alternative jurisdictions have surged, with traditional destinations like New Zealand and Malta facing new competition from countries like the Maldives, Argentina, and Turkey, which are offering residency and citizenship schemes. Milan and Singapore are particularly popular. Milan attracts wealthy Europeans and fund managers with favorable flat-tax regimes and strong financial networks, while Singapore draws Indian and Chinese plutocrats with its efficient government, predictable legal system, and robust wealth management, despite stricter social mores and higher

The Weekly Digest

taxes. However, these alternatives are not perfect substitutes, facing their own political uncertainties and stringent regulatory environments, making a full return of expats to Dubai dependent on a lasting peace.

Investors fear another surge in inflation

Bond markets are convulsing globally, with government borrowing costs soaring and investors fearing another surge in inflation due to the Iran war and yawning deficits. Despite this, inflation-linked bonds (linkers or TIPS) have not moved significantly, with the ten-year "break-even" inflation rate remaining near the Federal Reserve's target. This puzzling behavior is attributed to the TIPS market's small size, illiquidity, and lack of arbitrage opportunities, making it an unreliable inflation predictor. The unique function of ordinary Treasury bonds as a safe haven during market turbulence also depresses their yields, further distorting the break-even. Therefore, while linkers offer protection against rising prices, they may not accurately reflect investor fears

The Weekly Digest

about future inflation.

How should economists treat morality?

Alvin Roth's "Moral Economics" explores "repugnant transactions"—where buyers and sellers want to transact but third parties object—using examples like heroin vs. hitmen, horsemeat, and surrogacy. Roth argues morality shapes markets, highlighting the trade-offs of prohibition. While the book provides useful evidence on when bans work, it often treats morality as an "exogenous constraint" rather than a reasoned position. This misses an opportunity for deeper engagement on principles, though Roth himself appears deeply moral. The concept of repugnance, beyond social control, also plays a role in social cohesion by defining sacred and profane, suggesting societies that treat everything as tradable may struggle to maintain tacit cooperation.

SCIENCE & TECHNOLOGY

Breakthroughs for batteries could soon make them much better

The lithium-ion battery, long a champion, is stagnating, reaching its theoretical limits and prone to issues like cold-weather performance and combustion, driving urgent demand for better alternatives. Advances in materials science are now poised to revolutionize batteries, with solid-state cells emerging as a leading contender, offering higher energy densities (up to 500 Wh/kg) and improved safety. Researchers are overcoming barriers like brittleness through layered ceramic and polymer electrolytes, and a new understanding of dendrite formation suggests focusing on chemical stability in electrodes. Additionally, progress in sodium-ion solid-state batteries, utilizing abundant sodium metal anodes, promises even greater energy storage, while dry electrode manufacturing

The Weekly Digest

methods aim to cut production costs and boost performance.

The hantavirus outbreak is a tragedy?and a valuable data source

A hantavirus outbreak on the MV Hondius, with at least 11 confirmed cases and three deaths, serves as a valuable data source for epidemiologists studying virus transmission. The Andes strain, typically carried by South American rodents, is thought to have originated from prior exposure to rodent droppings, though human-to-human transmission is rare. Disease detectives on board are meticulously tracking interactions to assess transmission odds, adding to the understanding of this virus. While hantavirus is serious due to its high mortality rate, studies confirm it does not transmit easily between humans or show adaptations for widespread human infection, making it unlikely to pose a pandemic threat.

The Weekly Digest

Could microscopic spheres of silica help cool the planet?

Stardust Solutions, an Israeli startup, has revealed its secret technology for solar geoengineering: microscopic spheres made of amorphous silica, with some versions having a calcium carbonate core. Unlike the more commonly studied method of injecting sulfur-rich chemicals, Stardust claims its particles would be safer as silica is not a health concern. However, this claim is met with skepticism from leading geoengineering researchers, who question the long-term safety of weathered particles and the company's objectivity due to its commercial interests. Stardust's significant private funding and links to intelligence services also raise concerns about transparency and potential controversy in the highly debated field of solar geoengineering.

How well do anabolic steroids work?

Anabolic-androgenic steroids (AAS), chemical cousins

The Weekly Digest

of testosterone, are highly effective performance-enhancing drugs for boosting strength and power, as demonstrated by athletes like Mitchell Hooper at the Enhanced Games. Studies show significant increases in muscle mass and strength, even without exercise, and an even greater boost when combined with training. AAS also increase oxygen-carrying red blood cells, potentially aiding endurance, and may improve recovery. However, their use comes with serious side effects, including increased risk of heart disease, infertility, testicular shrinkage in men, and clitoral enlargement, hair growth, and voice deepening in women, with some users experiencing lifelong health complications.

CULTURE

A blind tasting revolutionised the wine world 50 years ago

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The "Judgment of Paris" in 1976, a blind tasting organized by English wine merchant Steven Spurrier, unexpectedly saw Californian wines (Stag's Leap and Chateau Montelena) triumph over acclaimed French Bordeaux and Burgundy. This event, initially dismissed by the French as "Waterloo," profoundly impacted the wine world, sparking global demand for Californian wine and inspiring "new world" producers. Fifty years on, the anniversary is celebrated with events in Napa, while France largely downplays it. However, both regions now face a new crisis: falling wine consumption, changing consumer tastes away from "monster truck" reds, and economic pressures like oversupply and red tape, pushing winemakers to adapt with lighter styles and lower-tier offerings.

The unlikely inspiration for North Korea's first dictator

Jonathan Cheng's "Korean Messiah" argues that North Korea's communist dictatorship, despite being officially

The Weekly Digest

atheist, was deeply influenced by Christianity, particularly in Kim Il Sung's appropriation of religious rituals and dogma. Kim, whose parents were fervent Presbyterians, witnessed the power of faith to mobilize and inspire awe, later using these insights to suppress Christianity and forge his Juche ideology. Juche's "Ten Principles for the Monolithic Ideology" strikingly resemble the Ten Commandments, enforcing a cult-like devotion to the Kim family. While acknowledging other influences, Cheng's perspective reveals how the regime maintains power through indoctrination and persecution of rival belief systems, considering apostasy its greatest threat.

Why the sex in ?Rivals? is more than mere titillation

The hit TV drama "Rivals," returning for a second season, uses its abundant sex scenes as a metaphor for deeper themes beyond mere titillation. Set in the mid-1980s, the drama explores how sex signifies power

The Weekly Digest

and its abuses, freedom from social and corporate constraints, and the era's sexual prejudices like double standards and homophobia. Critically, sex in "Rivals" also frequently represents loneliness, serving as a salve or a sign of compulsive, isolating behavior. The series, an ode to frank marriages and the intersections of fate, places the most profound action in the bedroom, blurring lines with the boardroom, asserting that everything comes down to sex, except sex itself, which is often about something else entirely.

Not all Jews believed their future lay in Israel

Molly Crabapple's "Here Where We Live Is Our Country" revives the forgotten history of the Bundists, a socialist Jewish labor movement founded in 1897 that fiercely opposed Zionism. Bundists believed in "do'ikayt" (hereness)?that Jews had the right to freedom and dignity wherever they lived?and foresaw perpetual conflict arising from an Israeli state. Before the

The Weekly Digest

Holocaust, most Jews were not Zionists, with Orthodox, liberal, and pragmatic objections to the idea. Crabapple's personal and political history illustrates the Bund's commitment to fighting for Jewish rights alongside non-Jewish socialists, even as they faced persecution from both Soviet communists and Zionists. The Holocaust decimated the Bund, but its legacy offers a historical alternative for diaspora Jews seeking to celebrate their heritage without direct ties to Israel, especially amidst rising global criticism of Israel's actions in Gaza.

Beware the typo?and other lessons of literary history

Rebecca Lee's "Rogues, Widows and Orphans" offers an engaging look at how the written word goes wrong throughout literary history, from printers' omissions to censorship, plagiarism, and feuds. The book highlights the critical role of editors, or "correctors," in preventing blunders, such as the 1631 "Wicked Bible" which

The Weekly Digest

accidentally commanded "Thou shalt commit adultery." Lee explores instances of atrocious writing that sometimes achieve a unique genius, like Amanda McKittrick Ros's verbose novels. While acknowledging that "freedom to read remains a right constantly under siege," the book concludes by considering AI as both a threat and a promise to literary creation, capable of churning out vast, derivative content, posing a new challenge to human-authored works that have survived centuries of debacles.

Gamified novels?known as LitRPG?are a winning format

Gamified novels, or LitRPG, are gaining mainstream popularity, blending video game tropes like "leveling up" characters, XP, and stats with traditional storytelling, as seen in Matt Dinniman's "Dungeon Crawler Carl" series. This format, which originated in Asia and has been adapted by Western writers, appeals to gamers and audiophiles alike due to its immersive single perspective,

The Weekly Digest

fast-paced action, and regular "dopamine hits." Authors often self-publish online, interacting with readers who influence story development, and are finding significant financial success through early access subscriptions and bespoke rights deals with publishers. While not aiming for prestigious awards, LitRPG is filling a void between ponderous fantasy and "smutty romantasy," offering engaging, thrilling escapism for readers.

ECONOMIC & FINANCIAL INDICATORS

Economic data, commodities and markets

No significant coverage this issue.

OBITUARY

Edith Eger danced for Josef Mengele

The Weekly Digest

Edith Eger, known as the "Ballerina of Auschwitz," died at 98, leaving a legacy of resilience and a message of choosing happiness in the face of insurmountable past trauma. At 17, she danced "The Blue Danube" for Josef Mengele in Auschwitz, mentally transporting herself to the Budapest opera house to survive. After the war, she initially struggled with PTSD in America, but later became a psychologist and bestselling author, sharing her philosophy that while the past cannot be changed, one can choose their response to it. Her experiences, including witnessing horrific acts and the loss of her family, informed her belief that there is no hierarchy of suffering and that personal choice in finding love and happiness is always possible.